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ARMED TO THE TEETH, MASKED TALIBAN FIGHTERS FLASH THE VICTORY SIGN

Why India has to WORRY

The Taliban's rise in Pakistan has dangerous portents for India that a new government will have to address

By Saurabh Shukla

The writing was etched on the wall, but for the Zardari Government the existential threat was overlooked by the trappings of power. For India, which has strategic stakes in the stability of its nuclear-armed neighbour, sensing that Pakistan may be on a brink of collapse is a scary scenario that has kept Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and his national security team preoccupied even in times of a cliff hanger of a general election. "The spread of religious fundamentalism and terrorism close to our border is a cause of worry. Earlier too, a number of Taliban militants were involved in terrorist activities in J&K," warns S.K. Lambah, the prime minister's special envoy for Afghanistan and Pakistan. So after May 16, the new government in Delhi has a major fire-fighting exercise to do given the rag-

ing fire in the neighbourhood especially in Pakistan where the aftershocks of an advancing Taliban need to be tackled on a priority basis.

The threat to India: The chances of the militia knocking at India's door are remote, but the prospect of a rogue regime without a state control is fraught with dangers. This will require urgent attention of the new government. The possibility of Taliban taking over parts of Pakistan poses a risk to the security of India and democracies around the world, as it may become a terror supermarket. For India even though Pakistan's military operations have brought a breather, a bigger concern is that despite exodus of people from Swat, Taliban has won local support because of its campaign against the landlords, who helped it advance in

the area. Strangely, the Taliban brand of socialism in Swat has only added to its popularity. Their coffers are also swelling as money flows in from the emerald mines which were earlier controlled by the government. Local Taliban commanders have allowed civilians to excavate emeralds after paying one-third royalty to the Taliban which has helped them earn enormous goodwill. Analysts believe that in the long run, if the terror infrastructure stays intact there is a likelihood of the Taliban moving towards the plains which would pose a direct threat to India. The Taliban's radical ideology may integrate radical groups within India to expand their presence and try to emulate a Taliban-style experiment in India.

Spiralling terrorism: In the aftermath of the Indian elections, intelligence reports have warned of an increase in terrorism from across the border. Infiltration figures from Pakistan this year have shot up to an all-time high of 180 incidents recorded in the first quarter of 2009, compared to 20 incidents reported in 2008—a clear warning of the shape of things to come. Estimates indicate that around 50 terror camps are still functional across the Line of Control, with armed recruits waiting to cross over and carry out terror strikes. But South Block sources say, a bigger concern are reports that point to the existence of over 20,000-30,000 unemployed youth, especially in Punjab and Sindh, who have been trained by radical jihadi groups and are now involved in extortions and attacks. A worry is that the Taliban may recruit these young men for expanding its presence. It may also find it easy to use the existing terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir to fuel its terror designs. While the belated military response against the Taliban may be having some impact, the refugee crisis may become unmanageable. Already international aid agencies are warning